



ERWC 12

Syllabus



Teacher

Mr. Finnigan



Room

D202



Email

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Office Hours

Tuesdays & Thursdays

After School (Book on Canvas)

Quick Reference Guide

Grades

- 40% Summative
 - Essays
 - Projects
 - Finals
- 30% Formative
 - Quizzes
 - Seminars
 - Discussions
- 30% Engagement
 - Notebooks
 - Worksheets
 - Scores On The Spot

Norms

- Always
 - Chromebook
 - Notebook
 - Utensil
- Lights up
 - hang loose
- Lights off
 - lock in (no tech, no talk)
- Before You Leave
 - Clear Your Workspace
 - Return Tools & Materials
 - Push in Your chair

Policies

Late Work:

Canvas > Home Page > *Late Work & Revision Guide*

AI Policy:

Canvas > Home Page > AI in English

Course Description

- This is a yearlong, CSU-designed course built for one job: to push you to read, write, speak, and listen in ways that'll serve you lifelong. Let's start with the name. *Expository*— same root as "expose. **In an ideal world, Expository writing exposes truth.** It's job is to **clarify and explain** as opposed to entertain, persuade, or immerse.

Here's a way to feel the difference: **good writing has a job to do; different jobs require different writing.**

Descriptive writing wants to *immerse you* in a scene, using sensory details.

Narrative writing wants to *hook you* with a compelling story.

Persuasive writing wants to *win you* to its side.

Expository writing wants to *teach you* the truth.

You'll **read** contemporary, often contested issues, **learn** what's in the media's bag of tricks.

You'll **hold multiple perspectives** *before* committing to a position, and **build** arguments that can survive contact with a skeptic.

Rhetorical awareness, argumentative writing, and the metacognition (awareness of your own thinking) to steer yourself toward getting better at both. **That's the whole enchilada.**

Course Objectives



Critical Reading

Read past the gist. Find the claim, name the appeals, catch a flaw in logic.



Media Literacy

Understand the bag of tricks: ethos, pathos, logos, propaganda technique, manufactured urgency, algorithmic amplification.



Effective Writing

Dump, draft, cut, sharpen.
If a word isn't doing work, it doesn't survive the editing floor.



Synthesis & Design Thinking

Transform a heap of information from a mess into an intelligible form.



Research

Track down credible sources and make the evidence carry the argument.



Reflection

Notice your own thinking — where you started, how it evolved, where to go next.

Build Community

Establish new connections

Self Governance

Establish group-regulation and self direction.



Troubleshoot

Debugging and problem solving

Process Over Product

Focus on *how* you work, not *what* you produce

Required Materials



Chromebook

Keep it charged.



Notebook

Keep it neat.



Utensil

Keep it sharp.

Where Stuff Lives



Content | Canvas

Grades | Powerschool

If Class Were A Book

- **Modules are its chapters**
 - Some are long (6-8 weeks)
 - Some are short (1-2 weeks)
- **We'll do anywhere from 6-10 this year.**

Download the App

Comments: This serves as the official record for your overall course grade.

Updated 5–8 times per quarter

At times I'll make rounds with an iPad to grade you on the spot as you demo a targeted skill.

Forms Covered

Text-Based

Essays, articles, op-eds, narrative non-fiction, satire, one full length novel.

Audio & Video-Based

Feature film, independent journalism, graduation speeches, political ads, stand-up comedy, podcasts.

Visual & Art

Infographics, diagrams, photography, propaganda posters, protest art, memes and political cartoons, advertising and branding.

Poetry & Lyrics

Free verse, spoken word and slam poetry, protest songs, hip-hop, folk music.



Skills Covered

Media Literacy

- Find out what's in the bag of tricks — logos, pathos, ethos, propaganda techniques, manufactured urgency, logical fallacies, algorithmic amplification.

Digital Literacy

- Sort the signal from the noise, make it legible at a glance.
- Write, format, and build content specifically for digital spaces (e.g., docs, slide canva, or sites).

Design Thinking

- Take a pile of information and give it a shape; that is, sketch, test, and refine visual layouts (slides, charts, diagrams) to convey complex ideas.

Reading

- Paraphrase *before* you analyze
- Get beyond the gist. Spot a claim, name an appeals, catch a flaw in logic.

Writing

- Brainstorms, draft sprints, selective revisions, editing, polishing.
- Brevity baby. **If you can cut a word and lose nothing, cut it.**
- Every word should be doing work.

Speaking

- Storytelling and presentation skills - pitch inflection, varied rhythm, hand and body movement — all core abilities to grab the room.
- Prepare to explain the choices you make during presentations, Socratic seminars.

Listening

- Sure you can read the page, but can you read the room?
- Body language, interview skills, deep listening

Reflection

- Notice your own thinking — where you started, how it evolved, why it changed, and what to work on next.



Sample Unit: *Who's Allowed to Change Your Mind?* — Persuasion & Propaganda

Essential Questions

- Where do you draw the line between persuasion and manipulation?
- How do propaganda techniques *differ* across form — ad, speech, meme, campaign spot?
- What's our responsibility as an audience?

Standards Focus: Reading informational text (RI.12.1–10), rhetorical analysis (RI.12.6), argumentative writing (W.12.1), synthesis across sources (W.12.7–9), academic discussion (SL.12.1).

Weeks 1–2: Introduction & Context

1

- TED Talk: Renée DiResta, "How I Learned to Stop Worrying and Love Conspiracy Theories"
- Edward Bernays, *Propaganda* (1928), opening chapter excerpt
- Media literacy infographic: propaganda techniques primer (name-calling, bandwagon, testimonial, card stacking, glittering generalities)
- Discussion: digital habits and daily exposure to clickbait, ragebait, and persuasion tactics

2

Weeks 3–4: Reading & Response

- George Orwell, "Politics and the English Language" (excerpt)
- Aristotle, *Rhetoric* — ethos/pathos/logos excerpt
- Annotation and SOAPSTone analysis applied to a political campaign ad
- Propaganda technique and fallacy tagging across two assigned texts

Weeks 5–6: Application & Synthesis

3

- Meme rhetoric workshop: analyzing memes as persuasion artifacts
- Group synthesis activity: charting propaganda techniques across an ad, a speech, and a meme
- Socratic seminar: Is all persuasion manipulation, or is manipulation just persuasion done badly?

4

Week 7: Writing & Reflection

- Argumentative essay: claim about where persuasion ends and manipulation begins, using evidence from at least three module texts
- Build-your-own propaganda piece with a reflective annotation naming the techniques used
- Reflective journal: how has this unit changed how you consume media?

Norms and Routines

Learn the Rhythm

Start of Class

- Lights Up, Music on, hang loose.
- Get these ready to go
 - Notebook, Chromebook, Utensil.
- Lights Down? Music Off?
- **That's your cue.** Eyes to center.

We Work In Bursts

- 6-10 minutes at a stretch.
- **This is where you lock in.**
 - No tech, no talk.

Then We Chill

- Lights up Music's on
- This is your time.
- Relax.

This Cycle Repeats

- Get it right, we finish early
- Get it wrong, we work to the bell.

Norms

Learn New Skills

- Ask me what I have

Lend a Hand

- I almost always have things you can do that involve improving the space or optimizing our systems.
- Will trade for snacks

Keep It Clean

- Make a mess? Clean it up.
- Broom, wet mop, claw, I got you.
- Labeled receptacles are by the door

Before You Go

- Push your chair in
- Notebook to cabinet
- Equipment to its home.

Values to Embody



Volunteerism

Don't cross your arms and sit in the back seat. Speak up, be seen, ask questions, share your thoughts, and **volunteer to demo**. I can't carry us. It's up to *you* to make this class come alive.



Process Over Product

The formula's simple: pay attention to *how* you work rather than *what* you produce

"Ever tried. Ever failed. No matter. Try again. Fail again. Fail better" - Samuel Beckett



Visual Design

Mind the *visual* quality of your notebook, how you arrange the information, the whitespace, the section headers, using graphics and color intentionally.



Forge Connections

Resist the temptation to associate only with those who you're already close with.

"Sometimes it's a form of love just to talk to somebody that you have nothing in common with and still be fascinated by their presence." - David Byrne



Presence

It's in the eyes. Shut your laptop, pocket your phone. Stay with it.



Troubleshoot

The ability to debug is a core life skill. Complex problems rarely work the first try.

When you get stuck, how do you respond? If it didn't work, ask why?



Self Direction

Take the reins. Ditch the idea that somebody will *hand* you an education. Go out and grab it.

Consequences To Avoid



How To Fall Behind

Nobody falls behind because of one bad day. It almost *always* happens one of three ways:

1. They disappear.
2. They can't stop flapping their gums through transitions. Lights down, music off — that's a cue, not a suggestion. Sluggish transitions hold us up and kills the rhythm.
3. They opt out, cross their arms, refuse to work, disappear into their phone, and expect an easy pass. Don't be those people.

1

Side Eye

You'll know it when you see it.

2

Verbal

You'll know it when you hear it

3

Hallway

This is when we take it outside.

Note: This is where most students level with me.

4

Phone Home

Now ya done made me mad.

5

Referral

Exceedingly rare.

At this point I contact my boss, the VP of behavior and discipline, Mr. Davis.

Understand Your Grade

Engagement & Process (30%)

Happens often— 30 to 40 times a semester.

Notebook work, checkpoints, the small stuff that shows you're actually tracking what's going on in here.

This is where most people quietly bleed points.

Formative Assessments (30%)

Happens Occasionally

Quizzes, seminars, fishbowls, roughly twice or thrice a unit.

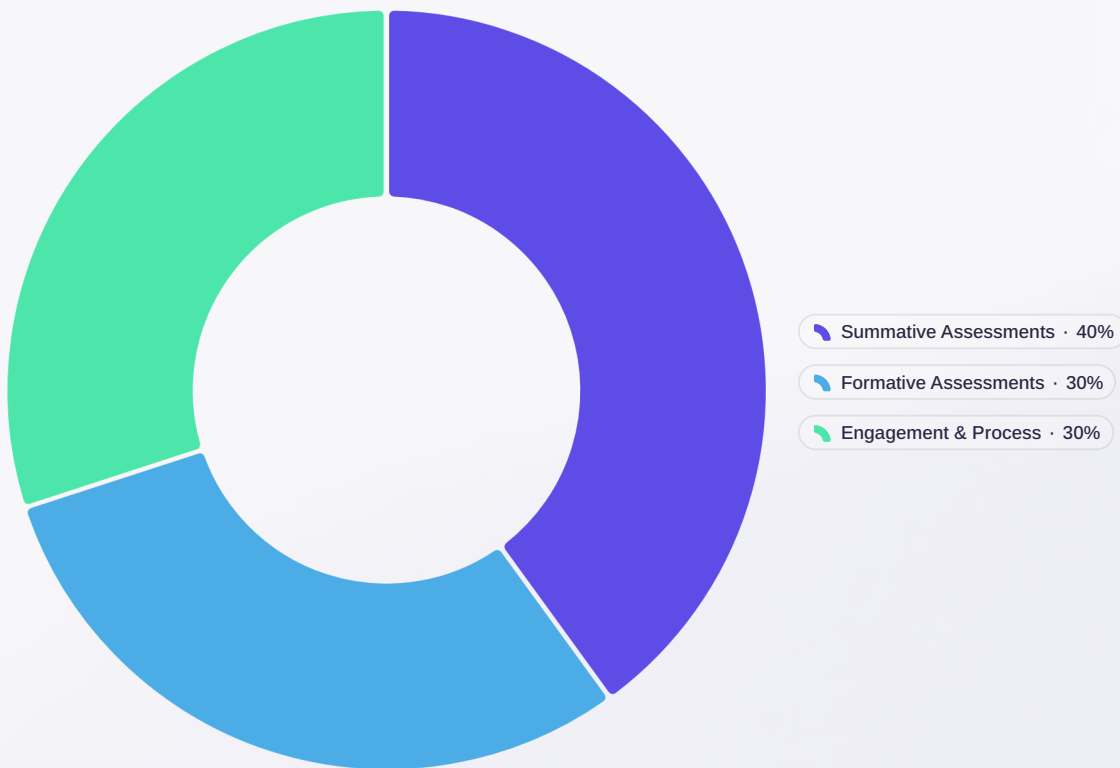
These are me checking your temperature mid-unit, not the final exam.

Summative Assessments (40%)

Happens Rarely

Essays, projects, presentations, the stuff that asks you to synthesize material covered through the unit.

Three or four times a semester, always at the end.



Common Misconception

- Your semester grade is not your two quarter grades averaged together.
- Get a 70% in Q1 and a 90% in Q2 and you'll go looking for an 80% — you won't find it.
- Semester grades run off cumulative points earned across the *entire* semester, sorted into three categories, weighted above.

Late Work

Day to Day Assignments (30%)

Daily Assignments

1-4 Work Days Late

85% Cap

1

2

5-10 Days Late

75% Cap

More than 10 Days Late

Just

Fuhgeddaboudit

3

Formative Assignments (30%)

Quiz

10 Days to Retake

1

2

Socratic Seminar

1 re-schedule per seminar. Miss that, you get one shot per year for 1-on-1.

Hard Deadlines

Aug 18

First Day of School (minimum day)

Oct 23rd

End of Quarter One

Thanksgiving Recess

11/23-11/27

Jan 16

End of 1st Semester

Jun 12

Last Day of School

AI Guidelines & Metaphors



Tractor's Impact on Agriculture

Tractors didn't replace farmers, it replaced the farm hands.
Field Hands no longer had to break their backs behind a plow — but farmers *still* had to know soil, growth cycles, pests, weather patterns.



Stairs vs. Escalator

When given the choice, most people take the latter. Sure they reached the top, but not because of their legs.
They let the power of the machine replaced the work, and their legs so it is with AI and your cognitive power. AI to think *for* you. Hand it the prompt, take the output, call it done.
Yeah you reached the top, but you built nothing - no muscle, no skill, nothing that's truly yours.
Striding up the escalator is using AI as an intelligent personal assistant, **a second brain** to argue with, to push back on your logic, to catch blind spots you'd never catch alone.
If you're on the escalator, don't just stand there, stride upward.



Nail guns vs. Hammers

A nail gun doesn't make you a carpenter, it makes a carpenter faster. Carpenters already know how to build houses, and can do it with hammers.
Hand that same nail gun to someone who never learned to use it and wait for calamity. The tool didn't fail. It worked as designed. The skill wasn't there.
AI rewards people who know how to think, and punishes people who use it to avoid learning how. Here's the split:

Skillful Use	Foolish Dependence
You built a draft, then ask AI to stress-test it	Used AI to draft, called it yours
You use it to check your reasoning	You outsource your reasoning to; in other words, let it decide.
You can explain every line you turned in	You couldn't defend your own paragraph if I asked
You left the chat smarter, sharper, better equipped.	You left the chat with a body of text to paste.



Gut-check: before you use it, answer me this: could you make a rough version without it?

If yes — great, use AI to sharpen, speed up, or pressure-test your thinking.

If no — don't use it. Ask what skill you haven't built, and hone it. Use AI *after* you've struggled, not *instead* of struggling.

Make Yourself Visible

- ✓ The best students I've known share one thing in common: **they're comfortable approaching teachers**. Before class, during breaks, after class, **come up front and chat with me**, informally, or about the work. It makes a difference.



Lunch

Open for business.

Even if it's just to hang.

Tuesdays & Thursdays



Office Hours

Canvas > Home

Tuesdays and Thursdays
after school in D202



Come Ready

Bring something specific we
can improve upon together.

